First Inaugural Address

President Abraham Lincoln · March 4, 1861

Source: Abraham Lincoln, First Inaugural Address (March 4, 1861), text via the Avalon Project, Yale Law School. Public domain.

By the time Lincoln took the oath of office, seven Deep South states had already seceded and formed the Confederate States of America. Fort Sumter was still in Union hands but running low on supplies. Lincoln's address tried to do two things at once: reassure white Southerners that he would not interfere with slavery where it existed, and insist that the Union was perpetual and that secession was constitutionally impossible.

Connect: Lincoln in 1861 sounded conciliatory about slavery in the South. How is this consistent — or inconsistent — with the Republican platform he ran on?

Key Passages

On slavery where it exists

I have no purpose, directly or indirectly, to interfere with the institution of slavery in the States where it exists. I believe I have no lawful right to do so, and I have no inclination to do so.

On secession

It follows from these views that no State upon its own mere motion can lawfully get out of the Union; that resolves and ordinances to that effect are legally void, and that acts of violence within any State or States against the authority of the United States are insurrectionary or revolutionary, according to circumstances.

Closing — 'mystic chords of memory'

We are not enemies, but friends. We must not be enemies. Though passion may have strained it must not break our bonds of affection. The mystic chords of memory, stretching from every battlefield and patriot grave to every living heart and hearthstone all over this broad land, will yet swell the chorus of the Union, when again touched, as surely they will be, by the better angels of our nature.

HIPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	Seven Deep South states had seceded after Lincoln's election and formed the Confederacy; Fort Sumter was still held by Union troops but running low on supplies.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	Southerners (both in seceded states and slaveholding border states that had not left), Northerners, and the wider nation.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	Abraham Lincoln, a newly elected Republican president who opposed the spread of slavery but was committed above all to preserving the Union.
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. HIPP — Point of View: How does Lincoln's audience (both Northern AND Southern white voters) shape what he can and cannot say?
2. Identify ONE specific concession Lincoln makes and ONE line he refuses to cross.
3. Compare the tone of this address with his Second Inaugural in 1865. What changed?